



NATION
BUILDERS

SPIRIT OF INDIA SPECIAL

INDUS TOWERS Established 2007

With one lakh telecom towers shared among three companies in 16 circles in India, Indus Towers has cut costs and hastened the telecom revolution

A SHARED FRONTIER

When Akhil Gupta, deputy group CEO and managing director of Bharti Enterprises, called Arun Sarin, then chairman of Vodafone, and suggested they share their mobile towers, Sarin was shocked. While independent tower companies do exist, hardly anywhere, Gupta says, "have three fierce competitors tied up in the back-end to essentially fight each other in the streets in the front-end." In a sector as competitive as telecom, such a concept was pretty much unheard of. However, after hearing Gupta out, Vodafone saw the potential. Once a JV

was formed between them, they called Idea Cellular, another operator with a wide presence, and in December 2007, Indus Towers was formed.

Indus was formed as an independent tower company to provide passive infrastructure services to all operators in the country on a non-discriminatory basis. The three companies merged their towers (over 70,000) in 16 circles in India, with Bharti and Vodafone owning a 42 per cent stake each, while Idea holds 16 per cent. The idea was to optimally utilise their resources and cut back on the investment required to set up towers,

Akhil Gupta 53, Chairman

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